

The Iconography of the Spiritual Quest

The theme of the conference (MontaNika Conference) is the icon. We have talks on the painting of icons, the history and meaning of icons, and the use of iconography in the Church. This talk is not about painting or carving, how to make or use icons. Rather, it is how to BE an icon, rooted in the inherent quality of the Icon of God that is imbedded in our soul. It has to do with the human person being an icon of God, and how we actualize that through seeking God, and in our spiritual quest.

At the core of our being is the noetic aspect of our soul, which is implanted within us at the moment of conception. It is the focal point of the image (*eikon*) of God within us, indelible and impassible—that is, which cannot be erased, changed, damaged or corrupted. The *nous* (I use the Greek word here because the translations just confuse matters) is of an angelic nature, as angels are noetic beings, immortal but not eternal by nature. It is the “spiritual” aspect of our soul, united with the “natural” aspect of our soul, the rational mind. The *nous* is that faculty which allows us to perceive God, and other noetic beings such as angels, demons, and other human souls. When Adam was created, his noetic faculty was the controlling aspect of his consciousness. After the fall, it was superseded by the natural carnal aspect of the soul. It was not destroyed, but rather, buried. St Gregory of Nyssa’s image of the fountain with a mirror in the bottom, but where the water is dark and cloudy, and full of gunk. If you reach down and push away the dirt from the mirror, it shines brightly. Part of our task is to clean the mirror of our soul. This is just the beginning.

The theology of salvation of the Greek Fathers use an energetic model, rather than a static state model. In other words, you don’t “get saved” by saying a prayer and suddenly you are going to heaven no matter what you do. You don’t get transferred from the state of the “damned” to that of the “saved.” Rather, we understand salvation as *theosis*, deification, which is about the process of the actualization of that inborn potential of our human nature. The image of God within us is about pure dynamic potential that is actualized in likeness to God, by cooperation, synergy, with God’s will, to bring us to the fulfillment of the potential within us. Each human person is a unique creation of God, reflecting God’s infinite creativity. Each person is a logos of the Logos, each manifesting the image

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of the Creator in a distinct way. As the DNA is the plan for the development of a fetus or an infant, in which we can see that potential being actualized by physical growth into a child, teenager, adult; so also, the potential for spiritual growth is in the nous. The body grows by synergy with the environment, breathing oxygen, eating food, drinking water. The soul is nourished by love and affection, learning and growing emotionally and intellectually. So, the potential of the nous grows by synergy with grace, integrating the whole person, so that the image that God created manifests its full maturity by likeness to Christ in union with God. The potential of human nature does not mean simply that we become well-adjusted adults. The full potential of human nature is ultimately realized eschatologically: the complete deification of our whole being, so that when Christ comes again, we will be *like Him as He is*. It is revealed in the Resurrection of Christ, the forty days afterwards and the Ascension. That perfection is the gift of Resurrection.

Our task is to engage the spiritual quest through repentance, to transform our lives and bring ourselves into communion and synergy with God. To do this is the “iconography of the soul.” Salvation, *theosis*, is a lifelong task, and it is necessary to engage this process actively from the time we become conscious of God. We strive to bring all of the components of our being into synergy with God, physical, mental, spiritual; otherwise, the whole suffers from one or more parts being missing or undeveloped. It is the task of integration, becoming whole. The spiritual aspect is what holds it all together.

There are stages in the spiritual life. At some point, we have a spiritual awakening, where God becomes real to us, and we become aware of Him. We become aware that Jesus Christ is the Son of God, as if we are now living in three dimensions, not two. Once this happens, we can never go back. This is God’s calling us to know Him, to repent, to worship Him. It is a sign of His love. So, we begin to read the Bible, go to church, to pray. But these are only the basics, and we desire to not just know about God, but to know Him. There is still more, and we begin to realize that in God there is infinite depth beckoning us. So, we get baptized, repenting of our sins, and begin the sacramental life of communion. Some people stop here, content with formal religion. But we remain in the world,

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in Latin “secular,” or worldly, with our whole life compartmentalized, and dis-integrated.

If we really are seeking God, and take the call of God seriously, we feel the necessity of going deeper. We do this by ascetic spiritual discipline, first cleansing our lives, souls, minds and actions of all that is contrary to communion with God. It means to learn to deny ourselves, our self-centeredness, and desire for gratification; to not only cut off anger and hatred, but to exorcise these demons from our souls, especially resentment; and to bring ourselves under control. Purification is the first phase, which alternates with Illumination. Illumination comes through confessing our sins in repentance and receiving the grace of forgiveness through the priest by the absolution. That grace comes into our souls and our hearts and heals us. It also illumines what we have to deal with next. This cycle repeats many times. All the while, grace works in our souls. As we try to hold onto it, the divine energy of grace penetrates our whole being, strengthening us to fight against sin and our passions, sanctifying our souls and bodies.

Repentance, the process of *theosis*, is all about the transformation of our souls, their enlightenment and deification. It is not a quick process. But if we really engage in it and do our part to fight against and renounce our sins, passions, and afflictive thoughts, gradually we experience the healing of our souls. Our behavior changes as we learn to control our thoughts, which are the source of our passions. We become conscious of the Presence of God and let that awareness restructure our mind and heart. It leads us ever deeper into conscious communion with God in prayer.

Prayer is one of the most important elements in this. When we first learn to pray at home and in church, using Scripture, prayer books and the Psalter, the words shape our rational mind and we can learn not only the words of the prayers, but how the Church prays. This then deepens into prayer of the mind, using the same words and concepts. If we are diligent in prayer, especially if we begin to use the Jesus Prayer, the mind descends into the heart—that is, the meaning of the words enters into the heart, the nous—and eventually leads us to stillness, *hesychia*. This is the state of contemplative prayer, which is entirely silent: no

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words, concepts, images, ideas, and no movement. Contemplative prayer is awareness of God, and eventually, in God (St Isaac the Syrian). In other words, it is the awareness of the Kingdom of God and is itself the experience of salvation.

The basic ideas of this are laid out in the New Testament, in particular by the Apostle Paul who writes in Galatians:

Gal. 5:16-6:2 I say then: Walk in the Spirit, and you shall not fulfill the lust of the flesh. ¹⁷ For the flesh lusts against the Spirit, and the Spirit against the flesh; and these are contrary to one another, so that you do not do the things that you wish. ¹⁸ But if you are led by the Spirit, you are not under the law. Now the works of the flesh are evident, which are: adultery, fornication, uncleanness, lewdness, ²⁰ idolatry, sorcery, hatred, contentions, jealousies, outbursts of wrath, selfish ambitions, dissensions, heresies, ²¹ envy, murders, drunkenness, revelries, and the like; of which I tell you beforehand, just as I also told you in time past, that those who practice such things will not inherit the kingdom of God.

But the fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, longsuffering, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, ²³ gentleness, self-control. Against such there is no law. ²⁴ And those who are Christ's have crucified the flesh with its passions and desires. ²⁵ If we live in the Spirit, let us also walk in the Spirit. ²⁶ Let us not become conceited, provoking one another, envying one another. Brethren, if a man is overtaken in any trespass, you who are spiritual restore such a one in a spirit of gentleness, considering yourself lest you also be tempted. ² Bear one another's burdens and so fulfill the law of Christ.

St Paul puts the spiritual quest into stark terms: put aside the works of the flesh, which are contrary to the Spirit of God; but live according to the Spirit, crucifying the flesh with its passions and lusts. This is purification and illumination. The Fathers of the Church tell us how to do this: by self-denial and personal discipline, prayer and fasting, the Mysteries of the Church, and immersion in Scripture. No one else is going to do it for you, you have to do it yourself, and the Spirit will help you in that. This is the real substance of becoming an iconographer of the spirit. You put away all that distorts the image of God, through repentance, and God will give you the grace to live in fulfillment of His image and become more and more like Christ.

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Orthodox Christianity is a fundamentally ascetic religion, a transformative discipline that is holistic, affecting every aspect of our being. It takes time, and it is necessary to be patient and longsuffering. Youth and patience are mutually exclusive. But it is only by patient perseverance, through suffering, that we are able to attain the fulfillment of our goal. This is what it means to bear our cross. Jesus said, “And he who does not take his cross and follow after Me is not worthy of Me.” (Matt. 10:38)

Foundational in this spiritual quest for transformation is participation in the Holy Mysteries of the Church. Baptism and Chrismation are the beginning of our journey; but constantly thereafter need Confession and Communion. The Mysteries or Sacraments are the spiritual food by which we nourish our souls. The discipline of frequent confession, established by the Apostles (James, the Didache), and constant Communion of the Holy Mysteries provide the source of grace for the transformation of our lives. The goal of always being worthy to partake of Communion is an important incentive to keep our lives pure. Having to confess our shameful deeds is also an incentive, a negative incentive, as the Fathers tell us.

Confession is one of the most important factors in living a Christian spiritual life. We are constantly bombarded with temptations, trials and falls into sin. Confessing our sins, being accountable before God and another person, and having our sins forgiven, lifts the burden of our sins and guilt, heals our shame, and gives us the grace to persevere. The forgiveness of sins was the first gift Christ gave to the Church on the day of His Resurrection. He appeared to the Apostles in the Upper Room, said “Peace be unto you,” and gave them the gift of the Holy Spirit, saying “whosoever sins you forgive, they are forgiven; who’s sins you retain, they are retained” (John 20:23). This was the ordination of the disciples, who then became Apostles, sent out by Christ. This is distinct from the gift of the Spirit at Pentecost. This ordination spiritually transformed the disciples of Christ into priests, to bear sins and offer sacrifice for the remission of those sins. It is a share in the High Priesthood of Christ, and the ministry to offer that forgiveness of sins and reconciliation to God, to baptize, preach and teach. This charism is the content of the Apostolic Tradition, and it is passed on from generation to generation through the bishops in the Mystery of Ordination.

The Mysteries of the Church were given to us to nurture us on the spiritual journey of deification. The Mysteries or Sacraments are essential to the life of the Church because the ultimate Mystery is the Church herself, the Body of Christ, the

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Kingdom of God. The point of the sacraments is not that they transform the bread and wine, the oil, or water of baptism, into something new that bears the grace of God. They do this. But the real point is that we, the faithful who partake, are transformed into the Body of Christ, and bear and manifest the Presence of God in the world. On the personal level we must focus on the transformation in ourselves, in our own souls, through partaking of communion, so that we may live and abide in Communion with God and with all others. Each faithful Christian personally becomes the Mystery of Salvation made manifest, according to their degree of communion with God. This is the action of the Holy Spirit.

Communion with God has many aspects to it. First, it can be seen as synergy or cooperation with the Will of God, obedience and doing His will. St Paul talks about the Law of Moses as a tutor to the will of God, teaching the Jews how to live righteously in this world. The New Covenant in Jesus Christ has superseded the Law of Moses, because it is not about obedience to rules written on tablets of stone or in ink, but rather by the gift of the Holy Spirit the will of God is written in our hearts. When we intuitively do the Will of God, we are in synergy with Him, in communion by grace. When we disobey, we are out of communion. This is where confession comes in. The more we strive to maintain that communion, to be obedient to God by loving Him and our neighbors, the more we are transformed and become aware of God's Presence and His Grace. Then we actualize what it means to be a Sacrament of God's Presence, in our own person. Thus when we give to the poor, out of love and mercy, it is Christ who gives. We become transparent to Christ, and He acts through us.

Another aspect of communion with God is through prayer. As we discussed earlier, in the beginning of our spiritual journey, prayer is formal, either with books or in services, or it can be more free form, but often focused on asking for things. It can also be intercession for people who are suffering. This is good, and these kinds of prayer are always with us. But there is another type of prayer, more advance perhaps, where a meditative kind of prayer like the Jesus Prayer transforms into the prayer of the heart, that is, noetic prayer. The words, concepts and images drop away, and we are fully present to God and He to us.

St Isaac the Syrian has a short poem/prayer which puts this beautifully:

Let us take refuge in the Lord,
And ascend a little to the place

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Where thoughts dry up
And stirrings vanish,
Where memories fade away
And the passions die,
Where human nature become serene
And is transformed
As it stands in the other world.
(*St Isaac, v.2, X:28*)

Contemplative prayer is beyond thought and concepts, stirrings of the mind and without the incessant gnawing of the passions. It is truly a state of serenity, and ascent to the other world. In another place St Isaac defines salvation, immortal life, as “consciousness in God.” St Isaac says this is true knowledge of God. Contemplation grows into the experience of union with God. This is what Jesus refers to in His High Priestly Prayer:

“that they all may be one, as You, Father, are in Me, and I in You; that they also may be one in Us, that the world may believe that You sent Me. ²² And the glory which You gave Me I have given them, that they may be one just as We are one: ²³ I in them, and You in Me; that they may be made perfect in one, and that the world may know that You have sent Me, and have loved them as You have loved Me.” (John 17:21-23)

Communion means union with God. It does not mean that we are absorbed. But it means that by God’s grace and love, Jesus Christ unites us to Himself and shares His life with us, transforming our very being and deifying it, uniting us in Him to the Father by the Spirit. This union is our eschatological state, eternal life in Christ by the Spirit. This is also what it means to know God, “And this is eternal life, that they may know You, the only true God, and Jesus Christ whom You have sent” (John 17:3). To know God does not mean to know about Him. That is not spiritual understanding, but rational knowledge. It is of this world and knowledge of our mind. True knowledge of God is the mystery of union with Him, where we experience His Presence and grace, and are transformed as we stand in the other world. Contemplation takes us to the vision and experience of that other world, of the Kingdom of God.

There is an entire spectrum of spiritual maturity, from carnality where we are completely engulfed by our passions, sometimes having no awareness of the

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existence of God; to the level of the “natural” man, where we are in St Paul’s word, *psychikos* (*1 Cor 2:14*) mistranslated “natural,” but meaning “soulish” or psychological, stuck in our minds and rationalistic or materialistic understanding. The ultimate phase is *theosis*. We are often obsessed with rationalist explanations for everything, including religion. There may be an awareness of God, but the soul is not mature enough yet to move to the deeper levels. It has not yet been integrated by noetic awareness.

¹⁴ But the natural man does not receive the things of the Spirit of God, for they are foolishness to him; nor can he know them, because they are spiritually discerned. ¹⁵ But he who is spiritual judges all things, yet he himself is rightly judged by no one. ¹⁶ For “who has known the mind of the LORD that he may instruct Him?” But we have the mind of Christ. (1Cor.2:14-16)

Spiritual maturity is a profound state of union with God and is the highest level of spiritual attainment. It is to have the “nous of Christ.” To this point and beyond, God is the active partner. There are few who get to these most exalted states. But it is open to everyone who strives for spiritual maturity, not just for monks. This state of spiritual maturity is the state of the great elders, who not only have conquered their passions, but have overcome their egos, having no personal agendas, but are transparent to the love of God. They can judge things truly because they have noetic discernment. They have become transparent to Christ. This is the fruit of years of spiritual warfare with the passions, in order to be purified and illumined.

The battle with the passions is difficult, and sometimes it seems we are making no progress, or falling back. But as long as we struggle, the grace of God is there. The passions are deeply ingrained habits that are almost automatic (passions, like passive) reactions to certain kind of stimuli, whether an image or words, someone being mentioned or present, or whatever, that triggers a reaction. These reactions may be sins in themselves but are certainly distractions from God. The task is to keep God in remembrance, even in the midst of sin, and then immediately repent. What matters is to keep the awareness of God, and consciousness of repentance. If we persevere in this, we attain greater maturity as well as the wisdom which comes from living communion with God.

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If we are serious about our spiritual life and attaining higher levels of spiritual maturity we need to make it the priority of our life. Most of us are on the path, either just beginning, or somewhere in the middle. But there is always more. The attitude of the great elders, and the great saints, is, “I am the worst of all sinners.” They are more intensely aware of their sins, even the most petty or minimal transgressions, because they distract from the awareness of God and communion with Him. The deeper we go into life in communion with God, the more sensitive we become to the least distractions. We do not cease to be sinners in this world; but we can become more keenly watchful over our minds and hearts and live according to the Spirit.

The real struggle is to actualize the image of God within us and bring it to fulfillment of likeness to God. Each person has their own path, and how far they may get; but it is not a race. God is the judge, not any mortal human being. This is spiritual iconography, not done with paintbrushes on boards, but on our own souls by how we live our lives. Yet, it is not only us that are the iconographers. It is God who is the ultimate Iconographer, who implanted His image in us, and brings forth His Likeness by His grace and the gift of the Spirit. We are active participants in that project, letting Him guide us by obedience to His will, and ever trying to live in that ineffable union of love in Christ by the Holy Spirit with the Father.

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Presented at the MontaNika conference June 2024